A SHORT GUIDE FROM GROWTH PARTNER PROS

AI Trust Boundaries for Microsoft 365 Copilot

Where do we trust Copilot, where do we constrain it, and where does human accountability begin?

Prepared for Erin Hughes, Ph.D., The Haverford Trust Company. November 2026.

Copilot uses the access people already have

Most AI tools only know what you paste into them. Microsoft 365 Copilot works inside email, Teams, OneDrive and SharePoint, and it draws on what the person using it is allowed to open. Microsoft's own guidance says that if content is already overshared, Copilot can surface it to anyone who has access [1].

That's why I start with the work and the information it touches, not with the tool. For every Copilot use, I ask six questions, in this order.

1. **Owner**
   Who owns the outcome? One named person, with a title.
2. **Data**
   What does Copilot actually need to know for this task, and nothing more?
3. **Environment**
   Where is it processed, and who else touches it?
4. **Access**
   What can Copilot reach?
5. **Action**
   What can Copilot change, and does a person approve it first?
6. **Oversight**
   Where must a human decide, and how do we check what comes out?

> **It will feel familiar**
> These mirror controls a finance team already runs for money: a budget owner, need to know, approved vendors, system access, approval limits and review after the fact.

What stays human

Hiring, pay, promotion, reviews and anything a regulator could ask about stay with people. Copilot drafts and a person decides. For the 360 summaries, HR reads every summary before a manager sees it.

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WORTH CHECKING NOW

Three things to look at before HR files move

Each one is a short conversation with whoever manages your Microsoft 365 settings.

1. Whether Claude is switched on

Some Copilot features can use Claude, Anthropic's model. It's on by default for most commercial tenants outside the EU, EFTA and UK, and an admin can turn it off or limit it to chosen groups. Models labeled "Anthropic models with Data Retention" run under Anthropic's own terms, so compliance should review those before anyone uses them [2].

2. Who can already open what

Copilot can surface any file a person has access to, including files shared more widely than anyone meant. Microsoft provides reports that show broadly shared sites [3], and a setting that keeps a site out of Copilot while permissions are cleaned up [4]. Setting access before files move into SharePoint is much easier than fixing it after.

3. Whether Copilot activity is being kept

Purview can keep Copilot prompts and responses for as long as your records rules require, but Copilot has its own retention location, so existing policies don't cover it until someone adds it [5]. Audit records are kept 180 days by default [6].

What a full review covers

This page is the short version. A full review applies all six questions to each HR use of Copilot, sets the level of human approval for each one, goes through the relevant Microsoft 365 settings with whoever manages them, and leaves you with documentation your compliance team can stand behind. I'm happy to walk through what that would look like for Haverford.

Sources, checked November 10, 2026

[1] Microsoft Learn, Data protection and auditing for Microsoft Copilot: learn.microsoft.com/en-us/copilot/plan/architecture-data-protection-auditing

[2] Microsoft Learn, Claude models from Anthropic in Microsoft Online Services: learn.microsoft.com/en-us/copilot/implement/connect-to-ai-subprocessor

[3] Microsoft Learn, Data access governance reports for SharePoint sites: learn.microsoft.com/en-us/sharepoint/data-access-governance-reports

[4] Microsoft Learn, Restrict discovery of SharePoint sites and content: learn.microsoft.com/en-us/sharepoint/restricted-content-discovery

[5] Microsoft Learn training, Apply retention policies to Copilot prompts and responses: learn.microsoft.com/en-us/training/modules/purview-ai-secure-copilot/retention-copilot

[6] Microsoft Learn, Audit solutions in Microsoft Purview: learn.microsoft.com/en-us/purview/audit-solutions-overview

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